

admirer or the store security making sure you don't pocket that piece of jewelry you've been admiring. Instead, it might actually be someone who is being paid to study you and your shopping behavior. There are field researchers all over the United States who work in the science of shopping, tracking shoppers, and noting everything they do.

Author and consumer analyst Paco Underhill runs just such a company. Envirosell employs a team of trackers that travel the globe, studying consumers so that they can advise companies and businesses how best to market to them. Where is the best place to set a sales rack or a bench for men waiting for their female companions to try clothes on? Where in the store should shopping baskets be placed? Underhill and his patriots gather the pertinent information and unearth the secrets of all sorts of typical consumer behavior that can help a store owner figure out solutions to problems they didn't even know they had.

While research has traditionally included surveys, focus groups, retail sales analysis, and the actual observation of shoppers, like everything else in today's world, it has gone high-tech. Since the 1990s, companies such as Procter & Gamble, Intel Corp, and ConAgra Foods have been experimenting with various methods of computer simulation in studying consumer behavior.

In 2007, Kimberly-Clark's "virtual shopping" in a mobile testing unit in a high-tech studio attracted the attention of *The Wall Street Journal*. The studio allows researchers and designers to get a fast read on new product designs and ad displays without having to stage real-life tests. Instead, testing is done with virtual reality tools. The room, with floor-to-ceiling